2.2 Growth of the Cotton Industry

Today, economies all over the world are connected to each other in visible and sometimes not-so-visible ways. The same was true for two seemingly very different parts of the United States—the South and the North—in the 19th century.

MAIN IDEA A new invention enabled southern plantation owners to grow more crops and increase profits.

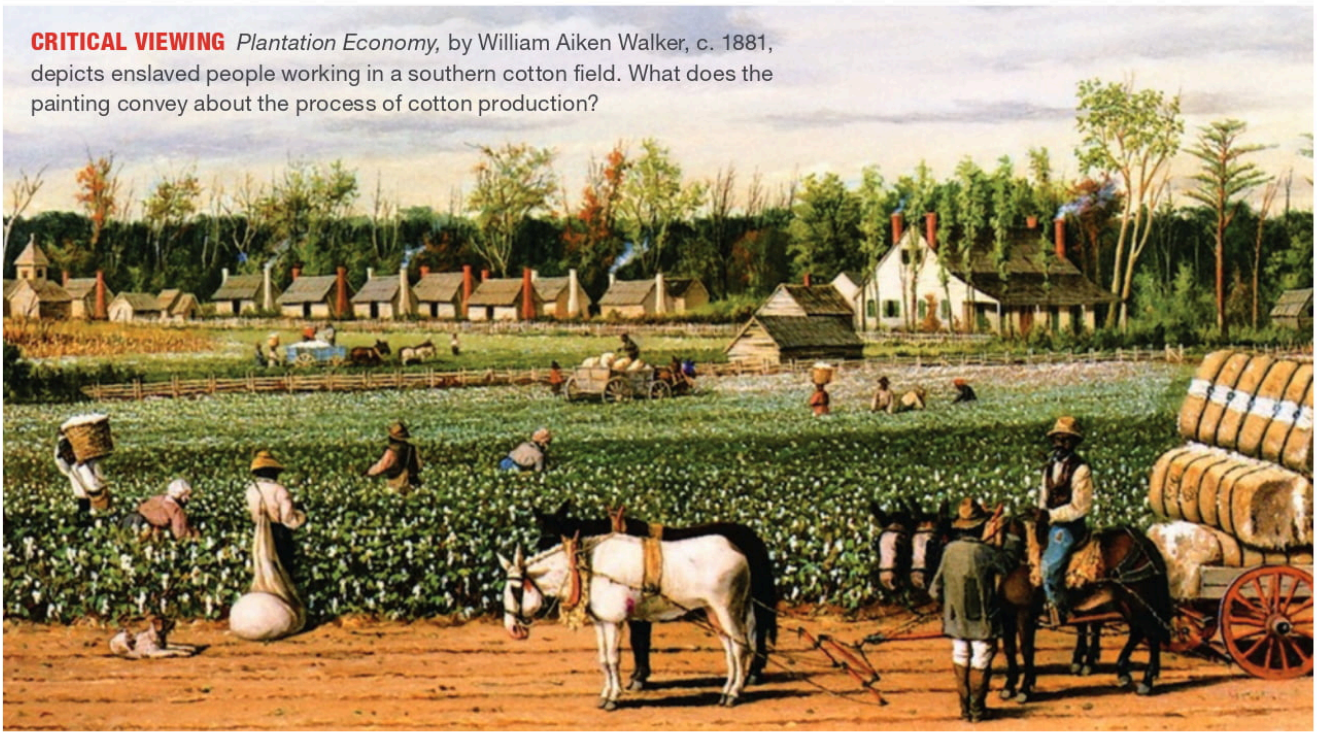
THE COTTON BOOM

The South differed from the North in several ways. For example, the South relied more on an agrarian economy, while the North was rapidly becoming a major industrial center. But one invention brought the two regions closer together.

In 1793, Eli Whitney visited a southern plantation and observed that the system used to remove seeds from picked cotton was slow and labor intensive. To solve this problem, he designed the **cotton gin**, which, as you have read, is a machine fitted with teeth to grab the seeds and separate them from cotton tufts. The cotton gin increased the productivity of enslaved laborers, and cotton became the main cash crop on many southern farms that had previously grown tobacco. Most southern farmers embraced cotton because years of tobacco cultivation had depleted the soil of the nutrients needed for growing healthy tobacco plants.

Because of more efficient cotton production in the early 19th century, cotton quickly became a central part of the U.S. economy. Both the South and the North relied on this crop. Slave labor produced the cotton and raw materials that enabled northern manufacturers, financiers, and other business interests to thrive. This, in turn, spurred a new consumer culture in individual families connected to the slave-based economy.

CRITICAL VIEWING *Plantation Economy,* by William Aiken Walker, c. 1881, depicts enslaved people working in a southern cotton field. What does the painting convey about the process of cotton production?



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The Slave Dwelling Project

In 2010, Joseph McGill began a series of overnight stays in houses once occupied by slaves. His experiences resulted in the Slave Dwelling Project. Its mission is to preserve the places where enslaved people lived. By 2016, he had visited slave dwellings in 17 states. McGill invites others to visit and sleep in these dwellings. The dwelling featured here is located at Magnolia Plantation in South Carolina.

SLAVERY EXPANDS

Even with the advent of the cotton gin, growing and picking cotton was labor intensive, and the production of cotton relied on the labor system created to support it: slavery. The "peculiar institution" of slavery shaped the South's political, social, economic, and cultural development.

Southern plantation owners who wanted to maximize their profits from cotton production tried to do so by acquiring more land. As you have read, in the early 19th century, the federal government intentionally seized Native American lands. So when some southern landowners and farmers did the same in order to expand their farmlands, they did so with the blessing of the federal government. This land grab forced tribes to leave the Southeast and move to relocation areas in the West. Many Native Americans were permanently displaced from their homes.

Southern plantation owners also tried to maximize profits by increasing their enslaved workforces. In January 1807, Congress passed a new law that would "prohibit the importation of slaves into any port or place within the jurisdiction of the United States … from any foreign kingdom, place, or country." However, the slave importation clause that had been inserted into the Constitution 20 years prior prevented this new law from taking effect until January 1808. Once enacted, the ban caused the **interstate slave trade**, or the slave trade *within* the United States, to increase. Slave owners urged enslaved women to have more children. They then sold some slaves at slave auctions to make a profit and bought others to staff their plantations with specially skilled enslaved workers. Slave auctions separated families. Enslaved communities responded to forced separations by broadening kinship bonds, which meant considering non-blood-related fellow slaves as family members.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What impact did the cotton gin have on cotton production?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did the interstate slave trade affect enslaved communities?
3. **EVALUATE** In what ways did the institution of slavery shape the economic development of both the South and the North?

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